

Translation Loss Game Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and Language • 25-30 min

Category	Knowledge and Language	Time	25-30 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	translation-loss-game

Big idea: Language carries cultural categories.

Overview

Students explore how language carries cultural concepts.

Student Prompt

Inspect Translation Loss Game Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Translation Loss Game Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A phrase translated literally, idiomatically, and culturally. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Translation Loss Game Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Words such as 'fair', 'home', 'respect', 'awkward', and 'saving face'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Translation Loss Game Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A ranking of what survives translation: fact, tone, value, or worldview. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Language carries cultural categories.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Translation Loss Game Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Translation Loss Game Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	Can all knowledge be translated?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how language carries cultural categories.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: A phrase translated literally, idiomatically, and culturally.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- A phrase translated literally, idiomatically, and culturally.
- Words such as 'fair', 'home', 'respect', 'awkward', and 'saving face'.
- A ranking of what survives translation: fact, tone, value, or worldview.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Groups attempt literal translations or definitions.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	They then write a cultural explanation or example situation.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	Groups identify what cannot be captured in one word.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Discuss whether translation transfers knowledge or recreates it.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may say language merely expresses thought rather than shaping interpretation.
- Students may identify bias in extreme examples but miss subtle framing.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Explains how wording changes interpretation before evidence is judged.
- Uses concrete language choices as evidence for a TOK claim.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Short lesson: use only the first example, one response grid, and one debrief question.
- Long lesson: add a second round where students revise the method and compare outcomes.
- Low-tech option: run with printed cards, sticky notes, and a board tally.

Extension Tasks

- Design a second version of the activity that tests the same knowledge issue in another AOK.
- Find a real-world example where the same knowledge problem matters outside the classroom.
- Write a 150-word TOK exhibition-style commentary using the activity as the object context.

Related Activities

- Loaded Headline Laboratory
- Metaphor Changes Policy
- Category Boundary Sorting